

How the War Changed Universities in Syria

In one page

The Syrian war did not just interrupt higher education. It changed what universities are, how they function, and who can realistically study in them.

1) Campuses became unsafe

Universities stopped being reliably protected places for learning. Campuses, dormitories, and teaching hospitals were damaged, militarized, or exposed to violence. Even in 2024, student housing at the University of Aleppo was struck by shelling.

2) Security control grew

The war appears to have deepened state-security influence over universities. Reports describe stronger surveillance, political pressure, and securitized campus management. In practice, this made academic life more constrained and less free.

3) Universities lost professors and expertise

Large numbers of academics left Syria or were displaced. This reduced teaching quality, weakened research, and forced some institutions to rely on less experienced staff. The war damaged not only buildings, but also the human capital that universities depend on.

4) Access became easier on paper, harder in reality

Some admission thresholds fell after 2011 because student demand dropped. But actual participation became harder because of poverty, displacement, transport costs, document problems, fear of arrest, and insecurity. So formal entry sometimes widened while real access worsened.

5) The student body changed

Reports suggest women became a larger share of university students after 2011, partly because men were more affected by migration, militarization, and conflict-related risks. Online and flexible study options also became more important.

6) Degrees became less portable

In some areas, qualifications became harder to recognize across borders or across conflict-divided parts of Syria. That weakened the labor-market value of degrees and made university a less predictable route into employment.

Bottom line

The war changed Syrian universities from relatively stable public institutions into a system marked by:

- insecurity
- politicization
- faculty loss
- unequal access
- weaker quality
- less certain career outcomes

Syria still has universities, but the war reshaped them structurally, not just temporarily.

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